

Chapter 10

Big Impact Energy

My dad quit smoking when I (Jen) was nine. I remember my age because it was halfway to adulthood, eighteen, and I was convinced that if he smoked past my ninth birthday, I'd become so accustomed to it that I would start smoking too. My logic has always erred on the side of pessimism. But he must've taken me seriously because just before my ninth birthday he took me out back, handed me his last pack of cigarettes, and told me to break them in half. The pack was about half full, but I remember I had to do several at a time because I couldn't get all of them. With each break, light brown flaky Marlboro bits burst open like confetti until they were all broken, lying in a pile at the bottom of a trash can with no bag in it.

My dad never picked up another cigarette. His cold turkey quit wasn't surprising. He was a recovering alcoholic who quit drinking cold turkey when my mom refused his marriage proposal until he got sober. And there was never a drop of alcohol in our house or at any of our social gatherings my entire youth. I don't know if cigarettes were how he gave up drinking, but I do know he replaced his cigarettes with Popsicles. From that day on we could never have enough Popsicles in the house. As a construction worker, I don't think he had access to them at work, so when he got home there was almost always one in his hand. When the Popsicles showed up on his waistline, he got a stationary bike and would wake up at 5 a.m. every morning to spend an hour on the bike.

He died of cirrhosis when I was sixteen, even after twenty years of sobriety. The undiagnosed hepatitis C had progressed too far to treat. While